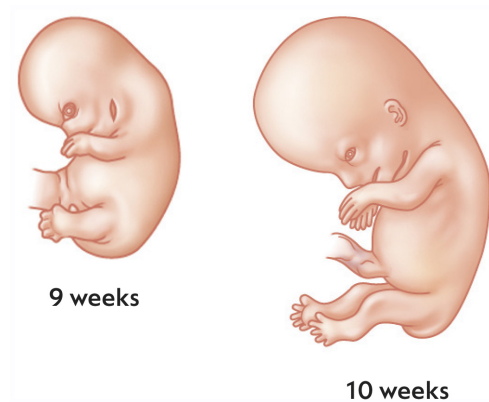




ASK A DOCTOR

I've been told I might be rhesus negative. What does this mean? Red blood carries a positive or negative rhesus factor (Rh-factor). Problems arise if an Rh-negative woman carries an Rh-positive baby who has inherited the Rh-positive status from the father. If the mother's blood comes into contact with the baby's during delivery, she may produce antibodies against it.

Although this may not be a problem in the first pregnancy, the antibodies can affect a baby in subsequent pregnancies, leading to anemia. To prevent this from happening, anti-D injections are given at week 28 and possibly again after the birth.

In some units, it is also possible to have your blood tested for fragments of your baby's blood to determine whether the baby is rhesus negative or positive.